The Hillingdon Hospitals
NHS Foundation Trust

Maternity Viewing and Taking Baby Home after a Stillbirth or Neonatal Death

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Version	Author	Summary of changes
1.0	Leila Abdou, Bereavement Midwife	New guideline following Human Tissue Authority visit.

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1. Aim/ Purpose

This document is guidance for staff when a parent wishes to view and take their baby home after a stillbirth or neonatal death.

2. Scope/Introduction

It is important for bereaved parents and staff to know that in England there is no legal reason a parent cannot take their baby home after their baby has died.

All bereaved parents should be offered the opportunity to take their baby's body home. Some parents will want to take their baby's body home and others will not.

The only circumstance in which this is not possible is when a Medical Certificate of Cause of Death (MCCD) cannot be issued, and the death is being referred to the coroner or procurator fiscal. If this is the case the parents must be informed that they can still take their baby home if they wish once the postmortem has been completed.

There are no other legal reasons to prevent parents from taking their baby home, if a parent does choose to do so they should be supported with their choice and advised correctly on how to transport baby to their home and what to do next in regard to a private/hospital funeral and when and where they would need to bring the baby back to.

Viewing the baby on the ward

Viewings for babies are sometimes performed in the Maternity unit / Gynae ward. This can either be before the baby goes to the Mortuary, or afterwards if the ward staff can facilitate this on the ward.

To ensure the correct baby is prepared, a 'Viewing Request Form' (appendix 1), must be completed and then signed by the *relative/s coming to view the baby. This is to meet the standards set by the Human Tissue Authority as 3 patient identifiers must be confirmed before a viewing can take place. If the baby hasn't lived, then all details will be in the mum's name. On the Viewing Request form the details can written as the mums e.g. "baby of……..."

Further considerations: Some babies are not in a viewable condition. It is up to the ward staff to assess and make that decision if viewing is appropriate.

3. The Procedure/Process

The following process must be discussed with parents in detail before they are discharged home.

- Parents should understand the choices they have when taking baby home, if English is not their first language, please make sure you use an interpreter.
- Parents must be advised sensitively around any changes that may happen to baby's appearance whilst baby is at home with them.
- The portable cuddle cot in Snowdrop should be loaned to the parents and signed out by themselves and the member of staff loaning it to them.
- Parents should be taught how to use the cuddle cot equipment and be confident in using it before discharge.
- Check three identifiers e.g. address, date of birth and name.

- The discharge of the deceased baby home must be documented on Cerner.
- All relevant discharge documentation must be up to date prior to discharge.
- All relevant staff should be notified of discharge and baby's whereabouts.
- Bereavement Midwife must be notified and informed that baby is at home with them, if discharged out of area then the local community midwives going out to visit parents must be informed prior to their visit.
- Parents must be given THH taking baby home document which must be signed by the parents and discharging midwife prior to discharge in the event of a traffic accident (see appendix 1).
- Parents must use their own private transport and not transport baby on any form of public transport.
- Baby must be securely fastened in a baby care seat, Moses basket or can be held by mother for the journey home.
- Babys information to remain on labour wards board until baby has been returned to the hospital mortuary or funeral director.
- Bereavement Midwife to collect cuddle cot when no longer in use or parents to arrange for cuddle cot to be brought back to the hospital.

Please note: You do not need to inform the police when discharging a baby home with their parents.

Preparing the Viewing

- Set up the baby crib or cold cot.
- Check ID band corresponds with the names given by the member of staff/ family asking for the viewing and any from the following to give 3 identifiers: date of death, date of birth, mother's address, and ward.
- Make sure the baby is presentable e.g. eyes closed and clean.

Ward staff ask the relatives to take a seat and complete the Viewing Request form, then will check the babies ID band corresponds with the details on the Viewing Request Form before bringing the parents in to see baby.

Once the viewing on the ward has finished, bleep the Porters to collect baby and be bought back to the Mortuary.

4. Roles and Responsibilities

Bereavement midwife or Labour ward discharging midwife is responsible for following the correct guidance when discharging a baby home with their bereaved parents.

5. Training Need Identified

Training on how to use cuddle cot to be given to midwives working on labour ward, one to one and on each rotation.

This clinical guideline, protocol or procedure will be monitored using local and national guidance and via the Trust Incident and Risk Management Policies. If risks/issues are identified further specific monitoring will be considered, for example, clinical audit or risk assessment.

6. References

National Bereavement Care Pathway (2022) *Stillbirth.* Available at: https://nbcpathway.org.uk/sites/default/files/2022-08/NBCP%20Stillbirth%20July%202022.pdf (Accessed 25th April 2024).

SANDS Position Statement Taking the Baby Home (2015) *Improving Bereavement Care Team.* Available at:

Position statement Taking the baby home_2.pdf (sands.org.uk) (Accessed 25th April 2024)

University Hospitals of Leicester NHS Trust (2022) Taking a Deceased Child Home, *Cuddle Cot Loan Agreement*. Available at: Taking a Deceased Child or Infant Home (where registerable birth) UHL Childrens Policy.pdf (leicestershospitals.nhs.uk) (Accessed on 25th April 2024)

7. Appendices

1. Taking a baby home discharge letter
2. Cuddle cot loan agreement
3. Viewing Request Form

Appendix 1

TO WHOM IT MAY CONCERN This is to confirm that (name(s) of parent(s))

_____

of (address)_____

_____

Who had a late miscarriage, stillbirth or neonatal death on (date)_____ have

taken their baby from (name and address of hospital) _____

_____ Date _____

Name of staff member (please print) _____

Position (please print) _____

In case of need or concern please contact: Staff member's name _____

Job Title_____ Department direct line _____

Parents Signature_____

24-hour phone contact for support_____

Appendix 2

Cuddle cot loan agreement.

I (parent's name) ……..

Of (address) ……

……

……

have taken a cuddle cot / cool blanket, from The Hillingdon Hospital Labour Ward

Date …… on short-term loan.

I have been given verbal information and a tutorial on how to use this safely and effectively.

I understand that I should try to keep my baby in the cuddle cot / blanket for most of the time due to natural changes that will happen in my child's body, that I have already discussed with the bereavement midwife/ nurse and doctor.

I agree to inform the bereavement team when I no longer require the cuddle cot, when a final arrangement for collection or drop off will be made.

IT IS AGREED THAT:

1. The Hillingdon Hospital has demonstrated and instructed the parents on how to prepare the equipment adequately and the intended use of the equipment.

2. The parent/s will be responsible for any costs that may incur, including the cost of repairs which arise from the failure to observe the conditions of this agreement, failure to comply with the instructions given by the Hospital on the operation, appropriate use or care of the equipment.

3. The Hospital shall make sure the equipment has been adequately checked and is up to date with maintenance testing, if the equipment fails then the hospital has a duty to provide a replacement.

4. The parent shall be wholly responsible for this equipment during this period and shall not allow anyone else to use it.

5. I am aware that in the event of any concern about this equipment, I have been given contact numbers of who to call. I have also signed and received a copy of the 'Taking my baby home' form: YES NO

Parental Name:

Signature:

Date:

Nurse/Midwife:

Signature:

Date:

Equipment returned to ward / unit ……

on: ....…….

Received by: …….
(Print and sign name)

Equipment checked & cleaned by: ..…….
(Print and sign name)

Job role: …….

Appendix 3

Viewing Request Form

Viewing Date and Time: …….……..

Ward: …….

Full name of baby/mother…….

Date of birth/date of death…….…….

Address of baby/mother…….

To be completed by relative to confirm the details above:

Name of person requesting viewing: …….…….

Relationship to baby: …….…….

Signature:……..……

We offer our condolences and thank you for your assistance with this request.

Ward Staff

Name: …….……...…….Signature: ……